Hunting through VPN logs in Kibana and Splunk

ANALYST	ROLE	ENVIRONMENT	HANDLING
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SUMMARY

I worked through a VPN connection log index in Kibana to narrow thousands of events down to the users, sources and time windows that actually needed attention, then ran the same kind of search in Splunk.

SCOPE

Lab-provided VPN logs in Elasticsearch, explored in Kibana Discover. Comparable searches in Splunk with SPL.

METHOD

1. Selected the right index pattern and set the time range before reading any results.
2. Explored the key fields: user, source IP, location and connection state.
3. Built KQL queries with AND, OR, NOT and wildcards.
4. Narrowed results with filter pills (is, is not, is one of, is not one of, exists, does not exist).
5. Used field statistics to spot outliers in users and source IPs.
6. Reproduced the search logic in Splunk with SPL.

FINDINGS

- Two of my own mistakes produced wrong counts: a malformed date comparison in KQL, and a time filter that did not match the range in my filter pill.
- Fixing both changed the result. I now confirm the time window and query syntax before trusting any number.
- Specific users, IPs and counts are left out so the room is not spoiled.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- Alert on VPN logins from new countries or ASNs, logins by disabled accounts and impossible travel.
- Save validated queries as saved searches so the team reuses tested logic.
- Record the exact query and time range in every ticket so results can be reproduced.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE ROLE

A SIEM is only as good as the query. Getting the time range and syntax right is part of the analysis, not a detail.